TCW 1103 · ENGINEERING COMMUNICATION SKILLS · PART 1

Written Communication, Meetings and Referencing

Memos, business letters (complaint, motivation, application), reports, abstracts and summaries, note-making, meetings (notice, agenda, minutes, chair and secretary), and Harvard and APA referencing. Formats you can reproduce in the exam room.

WHITEPAPER 2 OF 3

COURSE
TCW 1103 Engineering Communication Skills (Part 1)

DEPARTMENT
Civil & Water Engineering, NUST Faculty of Engineering

LECTURER
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PREPARED FOR
Group 13 · exam on Monday 26 October 2026

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Formats follow the fully blocked, open-punctuation style taught in Zimbabwean universities. Model documents are examples to adapt, not to copy word for word.

Group 13
Study Board

1 Oral versus written communication

Criterion	Oral	Written
Feedback	Immediate; questions answered on the spot	Delayed
Record	None unless minuted or recorded	Permanent; legal evidence; can be filed and audited
Precision	Lower; easily misremembered	Higher; can be checked, edited and approved
Speed and cost	Quick, cheap for simple matters	Slower; formal reports cost time
Non-verbal support	Rich: tone, gesture, expression	Only layout, punctuation and word choice
Reach	Limited to those present	Can reach many people, repeatedly
Best for	Urgent, simple, sensitive or persuasive matters	Complex, technical, legal or reference matters

Use **both** for important matters: brief the crew orally, then confirm in writing ("as discussed this morning, ...").

2 The writing process and plain English

Three stages (Guffey's 3-x-3)

1. **Prewriting**: analyse purpose and audience, anticipate the reader's reaction, choose the channel, gather facts, outline.
2. **Drafting**: write fast; topic sentences; logical order (direct for good or routine news, indirect for bad news or persuasion).
3. **Revising**: cut padding, check facts and figures, proofread, check format, then evaluate: will it achieve its purpose?

Plain English rules

- Average sentence 15–20 words
- One idea per paragraph
- Active voice: "The contractor **will repair** the leak" not "The leak will be repaired"
- Everyday words: "use" not "utilise"; "start" not "commence"
- Numbers, dates and names, not vague words
- Headings and lists for scanning
- The 7 C's as the final check (Whitepaper 1, §7)

3 The memorandum HOT

A **memorandum (memo)** is a short, formal written message used for communication **within** an organisation, to inform, instruct, request or record. It has no salutation, no inside address and no complimentary close. A memo travelling outside the organisation becomes a letter.

Features

- Internal only; on a memo form or letterhead
- Heading block: **TO, FROM, DATE, SUBJECT** (optionally CC, REF)
- Subject line states the purpose in a few words
- Opening sentence gives the main point
- Short numbered paragraphs
- Ends with the action required and deadline
- Initialled by the sender (not signed in full)

Uses

- Announcing meetings, training, policies
- Instructions and procedures
- Requests for resources or information
- Confirming oral agreements
- Short internal (memo) reports

Advantages

Quick, cheap, permanent record, reaches many people, clear accountability (who said what, when).

KARIBA CIVIL CONTRACTORS (PVT) LTD
INTERNAL MEMORANDUM

TO: All Workshop and Site Staff
FROM: T. Moyo, Workshop Engineer
CC: Construction Manager; SHE Officer
DATE: 22 October 2026
REF: WS/SAF/14/26
SUBJECT: **COMPULSORY SAFETY WORKSHOP ON THE NEW MACHINE-GUARDING STANDARD**

1. All workshop and site staff must attend a safety workshop on the new machine-guarding standard on Thursday 29 October 2026, from 08:00 to 11:00, in the Training Room, Block C.

2. The workshop follows two near-miss incidents on the bench grinder this month. It will cover the new fixed guards, lock-out/tag-out procedure and the reporting of defects.

3. Please bring your PPE and your employee number. Tea will be provided.

4. Attendance is compulsory. Confirm attendance with your shift supervisor by Tuesday 27 October 2026. Staff on leave will attend the repeat session on 5 November.

TM

EXAM SPOT HOT

NUST Aug 2015 Q6: "You are the workshop engineer... write a memo advising staff of the workshop" [10]. A class presentation "The memo defined and explained" covered it. **Format carries marks**: never leave out the heading block, subject line or the action/deadline. Do not write "Dear..." or "Yours faithfully" on a memo.

4 Business letters: layout and parts

The layout taught in Zimbabwe is **fully blocked with open punctuation**: every line starts at the left margin, no punctuation in the address block, date or salutation and close lines, one blank line between parts.

#	Part	Notes
1	**Sender's address / letterhead**	Top (right or left in personal letters; fully blocked = left). No name in a personal letter's address.
2	**Reference**	"Our ref / Your ref" in business letters.
3	**Date**	Written in full: 22 October 2026 (not 22/10/26).
4	**Inside address**	Title, name or designation, organisation, address of the receiver.
5	**Salutation**	"Dear Sir or Madam" (unknown) / "Dear Mr Ndlovu" (named).
6	**Subject heading**	In capitals or bold, below the salutation: RE: or the topic alone.
7	**Body**	Opening (purpose), middle (details), closing (action required).
8	**Complimentary close**	"Yours faithfully" with Dear Sir/Madam; "Yours sincerely" with a named person.
9	**Signature, name, designation**	Handwritten signature, typed name, job title.
10	**Enclosures / copies**	"Enc: Quotation" ; "cc: Finance Manager".

5 The complaint letter LIKELY

A **letter of complaint** formally informs an organisation of a problem with goods, services or conduct, gives evidence and requests a specific remedy. Tone: **firm, factual and courteous**, never abusive. Structure: (1)

purpose and background (what, when, order or account number); (2) the problem in detail, with facts and evidence; (3) effect on you; (4) the action you want and a reasonable deadline; (5) polite close.

Department of Civil and Water Engineering
National University of Science and Technology
PO Box AC 939
Ascot
Bulawayo

22 October 2026

The Sales Manager
Ascot Building Supplies
14 Fort Street
Bulawayo

Dear Sir or Madam

DEFECTIVE CEMENT DELIVERED ON INVOICE NO. 4471

On 15 October 2026 your company delivered 60 bags of 32.5N cement to our hydraulics laboratory under Invoice No. 4471. I am writing to complain that 18 of these bags were hardened and unusable.

The bags were lumpy on delivery, and the lumps do not break between the fingers, which shows that the cement had absorbed moisture before delivery. Photographs and the signed delivery note are enclosed. As a result, our concrete cube tests for 120 students have been postponed by one week.

I request that you replace the 18 bags at no cost and collect the damaged bags by Friday 30 October 2026. Please confirm the arrangement by telephone on 0292 828 000.

Yours faithfully

[signature]
R. Sibanda
Laboratory Technician

Enc: photographs (4); delivery note

The supplier and phone number are invented for practice.

Presenting complaints at work (class topic): use the proper channel (supervisor first, then HR or the grievance procedure); put it in writing; focus on facts and the impact, not personalities; propose a solution; keep records; stay calm and professional; follow up.

6 The motivation (cover) letter and the CV LIKELY

A **motivation letter** (cover letter, letter of application) accompanies a CV or an application for a job, attachment, scholarship or university place. It explains **why you want it** and **why you are the right person**, and asks for an interview. One page.

Structure

1. **Opening**: the post or programme, where you saw it, a one-line reason you are a fit.
2. **Body 1**: relevant qualifications and skills, with evidence.
3. **Body 2**: experience, projects, achievements (numbers).
4. **Body 3**: why this organisation (show research) and what you will contribute.
5. **Close**: availability, request an interview, thank the reader.

Do and don't

- Address a named person where possible
- Match your skills to the advert's keywords
- Give evidence, not adjectives ("led a team of 4 on a culvert design project")
- Positive, confident tone; no begging
- No spelling errors; one page; same contact details as the CV
- Don't repeat the CV line by line

The curriculum vitae (CV): personal details (name, contacts, not ID number or marital status unless asked); profile (2–3 lines); education (most recent first); skills (technical: AutoCAD, MS Excel, surveying; soft: teamwork, leadership); experience and projects; achievements and awards; interests; referees (two or three, with permission). Keep it 1–2 pages, clean and truthful.

7 Organisational reports HOT

A **report** is a formal, structured document that presents facts and findings on a specific subject, gathered through investigation, for a specific reader, usually with conclusions and recommendations to support decision-making. Reports are written in the **third person**, past tense for findings, with numbered headings.

Purposes

- Inform management (progress, status)
- Record events (incident, accident)
- Investigate a problem and recommend action
- Support decisions (feasibility, tender evaluation)
- Meet legal or regulatory requirements (EIA, inspection)
- Evaluate performance (monthly, annual)

Types

- **Informational** (facts only) vs **analytical** (analysis, conclusions, recommendations)
- **Formal** (long, full structure) vs **informal** (memo or letter report)
- **Routine/periodic** (daily site diary, monthly progress) vs **special** (one-off investigation)
- Engineering: **progress, incident/accident, inspection, feasibility, technical/laboratory, site visit, test, environmental impact**
- Oral report vs written report

Section of a formal report	Contents
Title page	Title, prepared for, prepared by, date, reference.
Executive summary / abstract	The whole report in 100–250 words: purpose, method, key findings, main recommendation (long reports).
Table of contents	Numbered headings and pages (long reports).
1. Terms of reference	Who asked for the report, what it must cover, by when.
2. Procedure / methodology	How the information was gathered: site visits, interviews, tests, questionnaires, documents.
3. Findings	Facts discovered, under numbered sub-headings, with tables and figures.
4. Conclusions	What the findings mean. No new facts.
5. Recommendations	Specific actions, who should do them, by when. Follow from the conclusions.
References and appendices	Sources; raw data, drawings, questionnaires.
Signature, name, designation, date	At the end of the body.

REPORT ON THE FLOODING OF THE CIVIL ENGINEERING LABORATORY CAR PARK

To: Chairperson, Department of Civil and Water Engineering **From:** Group 13 **Date:** 22 October 2026

1. Terms of reference. On 14 October 2026 the Chairperson asked Group 13 to investigate why the laboratory car park floods after rain and to recommend remedies by 23 October 2026.

2. Procedure. The group inspected the site on 16 and 19 October, measured levels with a dumpy level, interviewed the grounds supervisor and studied the 2019 drainage drawing.

3. Findings. 3.1 Two of the three gully inlets are blocked with silt and leaves. 3.2 The car park falls 1:250 towards the building instead of 1:80 towards the drain shown on the drawing. 3.3 No routine drain cleaning schedule exists.

4. Conclusions. Flooding is caused mainly by blocked inlets, made worse by inadequate fall.

5. Recommendations. 5.1 Grounds staff should clear all gullies before 30 October. 5.2 Works Department should introduce monthly drain cleaning. 5.3 The car park should be re-graded to 1:80 during the December shutdown.

[signed] T. K. Muzunze, for Group 13

EXAM SPOT HOT

"Organisational reports: definitions, types and purposes" was a class topic, and report writing is on almost every UZ, MSU and CUT communication paper. Expect either a **theory question** (define, types, purposes, structure) or a **task** ("Write a report to your Head of Department on..."). For a task, use the five numbered sections above; never put new facts in the conclusions.

8 Abstracts, summaries and note-making

An **abstract** is a short, self-contained summary of a longer document. A **descriptive** abstract says what the document covers; an **informative** abstract also gives the results and conclusions. For a technical process (NUST Dec 2014 Q4: "Write an abstract of not more than 100 words on hot forging"): (1) state what the process is; (2) the stages in order; (3) the result or product; (4) why it is used.

MODEL ABSTRACT · CONCRETE PRODUCTION (98 WORDS)

Concrete is a composite construction material made by mixing cement, fine aggregate, coarse aggregate and water in designed proportions. The materials are batched by mass, mixed until uniform, then transported and placed in formwork before initial set. The fresh concrete is compacted with poker vibrators to remove entrapped air, finished, and cured by keeping it moist for at least seven days while cement hydration develops strength. Quality is checked with slump tests on fresh concrete and cube tests at 7 and 28 days. Correct batching, compaction and curing produce dense, durable concrete for slabs, beams and foundations.

Summary (précis) technique

1. Read the passage twice; note the purpose.
2. Underline the main point of each paragraph (topic sentences).
3. Leave out examples, repetition, figures of speech, quotations.
4. Write in your own words, in continuous prose, same order.
5. Count words; meet the limit; give a title if asked.

Note-taking vs note-making

Note-taking is recording key points while listening (lectures, meetings). **Note-making** is creating notes from reading. Methods: linear/outline (headings and numbered points), **Cornell** (cue column, notes, summary), mind maps, flow charts and tables. Use abbreviations and symbols (→, ∴, ≈, w/), record sources, review within 24 hours.

9 Meetings HOT

A **meeting** is a gathering of two or more people, convened for a common purpose, to share information, discuss issues and make decisions, following agreed procedure. Types: **statutory** (required by law, such as a company's AGM), **annual general meeting (AGM)**, **extraordinary general meeting (EGM)** for urgent matters, **board** meetings, **committee** meetings, **departmental/staff** meetings, **site/progress** meetings, **disciplinary** hearings, informal meetings and virtual meetings.

Notice versus agenda (class presentation)

Aspect	Notice of meeting	Agenda
Purpose	Informs and invites: a meeting will take place	Lists the business to be discussed, in order
Answers	When, where, who, why	What, in what order, for what outcome
Contents	Title, date, time, venue or link, participants, convenor, RSVP	Numbered items, time allocation, lead person, expected outcome
Use	Before the meeting only	Before (preparation) and during (roadmap for the chair)
Length	Brief, logistical	More detailed

Notice and agenda are often sent together. The usual **order of agenda items**: 1. Opening and welcome; 2. Apologies for absence; 3. Minutes of the previous meeting; 4. Matters arising from the minutes; 5. Correspondence/reports; 6.–8. Specific items of business; 9. Any other business (AOB); 10. Date of next meeting; 11. Close.

Minutes

Minutes are the official written record of the proceedings and decisions of a meeting, prepared by the secretary, confirmed at the next meeting and signed by the chair. Types: **verbatim** (word for word, such as Parliament's Hansard), **narrative** (summary of discussion and decisions) and **resolution/action** minutes (decisions and who acts, by when). Written in the **past tense, reported speech, third person**, with numbered items matching the agenda.

MINUTES OF THE GROUP 13 STUDY COMMITTEE MEETING HELD ON 22 OCTOBER 2026 AT 14:00 IN ROOM E12

Present: K. Muzunze (Chairperson), S. Ncube (Secretary), T. Macheke, S. Chiworeso, R. Mubhika **Apologies:** W. Gwete **In attendance:** none

1. Opening. The Chairperson opened the meeting at 14:05 and welcomed members.

2. Minutes of the previous meeting. The minutes of 15 October were read, confirmed and signed as a true record. Proposed: T. Macheke; seconded: R. Mubhika.

3. Matters arising. The Secretary reported that the presentation files had been uploaded to the group board.

4. Exam revision. Members discussed the communication skills exam. It was resolved that each member would draft two model answers by Saturday. **Action:** all members.

5. AOB. None. **6. Next meeting.** 24 October 2026 at 10:00. **7. Close.** The meeting closed at 15:10.

Signed: _____ Chairperson Date: _____

10 Chairperson versus secretary HOT

Class topic: "Compare and contrast the duties of a chairman and that of a secretary." **Similarities**: both are office bearers; both prepare the agenda together before the meeting; both must know the standing orders; both sign the minutes (secretary writes, chair signs as a true record); both follow up decisions; both must be impartial and confidential.

Stage	Chairperson	Secretary
Before	Agrees the agenda with the secretary; studies the papers; ensures the meeting is properly called.	Books the venue; sends notice and agenda in good time; circulates the previous minutes and papers; arranges equipment.
During	Opens and closes the meeting; checks the quorum; keeps order and time; follows the agenda; lets everyone speak; rules on points of order; puts motions to the vote; has a casting vote; summarises decisions.	Reads apologies and minutes of the last meeting; reads correspondence; records attendance, discussion and decisions; advises on procedure and past decisions.
After	Signs the confirmed minutes; ensures decisions are carried out.	Writes and circulates the minutes; handles correspondence; files records; reminds members of their actions.
Role in short	Leader and controller of the meeting	Administrator and record keeper of the meeting

Meeting terminology (one-mark definitions)

Term	Meaning	Term	Meaning
Quorum	Minimum number of members needed for valid decisions	**Motion**	A formal proposal put to a meeting for decision
Proposer / seconder	Person who moves a motion / who supports it	**Resolution**	A motion that has been passed
Amendment	Change proposed to a motion	**Casting vote**	Chair's extra vote to break a tie
Nem. con.	No one voted against (some abstained)	**Unanimous**	Everyone voted in favour
Point of order	Query that procedure or rules are being broken	**Adjourn**	Postpone or break the meeting to a later time
Sine die	Adjourned with no date fixed	**Ex officio**	Member by virtue of office
Co-opt	Invite a non-member to join for expertise	**In camera**	In private, closed to the public
AOB	Any other business: minor items at the end	**Standing orders**	Rules governing how meetings are run
Abstain	Not vote either way	**Proxy**	Person authorised to vote for an absent member

11 Strengths and weaknesses of meetings; organising one

Strengths

- Two-way: immediate questions and feedback
- Pools knowledge and ideas from many people
- Joint decisions win commitment
- Coordinates departments (lateral communication)
- Builds teamwork and morale
- Minutes give an official record and accountability

Weaknesses

- Time-consuming and costly (salary hours)
- Dominant members or the chair can control the outcome
- Groupthink; shy members don't speak
- Decisions delayed ("refer to next meeting")
- Poor preparation wastes everyone's time
- Too many meetings reduce productive work

Organising a strategic meeting (NUST Dec 2014 Q3): (1) define the objective; (2) select participants who have the authority or information; (3) prepare and send notice and agenda with papers in advance; (4) choose time, venue and format; (5) arrange logistics (room, projector, refreshments, link for virtual members); (6) chair firmly: start on time, follow the agenda, involve everyone; (7) record decisions and actions; (8) circulate minutes quickly and follow up.

Disciplinary meetings (class topic). *Employer*: give written notice of the allegation, time and the right to representation; be impartial; let the employee respond; keep minutes; decide on evidence; communicate the outcome and right of appeal in writing (in Zimbabwe, follow the Labour Act and the employer's registered code of conduct). *Employee*: attend on time and dress formally; bring evidence and a representative; stay calm and respectful; listen fully; answer honestly and briefly; don't interrupt or argue; ask for the minutes; appeal through the proper channel if unhappy.

12 Referencing: Harvard and APA HOT

Referencing is acknowledging the sources of information and ideas you use, in the text and in a reference list. It is a communication tool because it shows the **credibility and origin** of information, lets the reader **find and check** sources, gives credit to authors and protects the writer from **plagiarism** (presenting another person's words or ideas as your own, which universities punish severely). Avoid plagiarism by quoting with quotation marks, paraphrasing in your own words and citing every source.

Source	Harvard (author-date)	APA 7th edition
In-text	(Groover, 2010) or Groover (2010) states...; with page: (Groover, 2010, p. 45)	(Groover, 2010) or Groover (2010); with page: (Groover, 2010, p. 45)
Two authors	(Ulrich and Eppinger, 2008)	(Ulrich & Eppinger, 2008)
3+ authors	(Proctor *et al.*, 2000)	(Proctor et al., 2000)
Book	Groover, M.P. (2010) *Fundamentals of Modern Manufacturing*. 4th edn. New York: John Wiley & Sons.	Groover, M. P. (2010). *Fundamentals of modern manufacturing* (4th ed.). John Wiley & Sons.
Journal article	Moyo, T. (2021) 'Water losses in Bulawayo', *Journal of Water Engineering*, 12(3), pp. 45–58.	Moyo, T. (2021). Water losses in Bulawayo. *Journal of Water Engineering, 12*(3), 45–58.
Website	ZINWA (2025) *Dam levels*. Available at: URL (Accessed: 20 October 2026).	ZINWA. (2025). *Dam levels*. URL
Government report	Biti, T. (2012) *The 2013 National Budget Statement*. Harare: Ministry of Finance.	Biti, T. (2012). *The 2013 national budget statement*. Ministry of Finance.

Main differences: Harvard writes the year in brackets with no full stop after it, "(2010) Title", "and" between authors, and keeps the place of publication; APA puts a full stop after the year "(2010).", uses sentence case for titles, "&" between authors, drops the place of publication and adds DOIs. **Both** list references alphabetically by surname and both must match the in-text citations exactly (the most heavily marked point).

USING REFERENCES INSIDE A PASSAGE (NUST DEC 2014 Q5C)

Modern manufacturing favours processes that reduce material waste while keeping dimensional accuracy (Groover, 2010). Decisions made at the concept stage strongly influence final cost and quality (Ulrich and Eppinger, 2008), and national investment in industry is shaped by fiscal policy, as the 2013 budget statement shows (Biti, 2012).

13 Whitepaper 2 exam spotter and practice questions

ONE-PAGE SUMMARY

- **Memo**: internal; TO/FROM/DATE/SUBJECT; no salutation or close; numbered paragraphs; action + deadline; initials.
- **Letter**: fully blocked, open punctuation; "Dear Sir or Madam → Yours faithfully"; "Dear Mr X → Yours sincerely"; subject heading.
- **Complaint**: facts, evidence, impact, specific remedy, deadline, polite.
- **Motivation letter**: why this post, why me (evidence), why this organisation, request interview; one page.
- **Report**: terms of reference → procedure → findings → conclusions → recommendations; third person; numbered.
- **Abstract**: what, stages, result, why; within the word limit.
- **Meetings**: notice (when/where/who/why) vs agenda (what/order/outcome); minutes = past tense, reported speech.
- **Chair** controls; **secretary** records and administers. Learn 10 meeting terms.
- **Referencing**: Harvard vs APA punctuation; alphabetical; in-text must match the list; avoid plagiarism.

PRACTICE QUESTIONS IN PAST-PAPER STYLE

1. You are the workshop engineer. A compulsory safety workshop has been organised for all staff. Write a memo advising them of the workshop. [10] Explain four advantages of the memo as a channel. [10]
2. Write a letter of complaint to a supplier who delivered defective materials to your site. [20]
3. Write a motivation letter applying for industrial attachment at a firm of consulting engineers. [20]
4. (a) Define an organisational report and discuss its purposes. [8] (b) Describe five types of reports used in engineering organisations. [12]
5. The library is always noisy during the examination period. Write a report to the University Librarian on the causes and recommend solutions. [20]
6. Distinguish between a notice of meeting and an agenda, and prepare an agenda for a site progress meeting. [20]
7. Compare and contrast the duties of a chairperson and a secretary before, during and after a meeting. [20]
8. Discuss the strengths and weaknesses of meetings as a means of communication in organisations. [20]
9. (a) Explain why referencing is a communication tool. [6] (b) Using the details provided, write a reference list in Harvard and in APA style. [8] (c) Show how you would use the sources in a short passage. [6]
10. Write an abstract of not more than 100 words on a construction process of your choice. [10] Describe the Cornell method of note-taking. [10]

MODEL ANSWER OUTLINE · Q8 STRENGTHS AND WEAKNESSES OF MEETINGS [20]

Introduction: define a meeting (2). Strengths, one paragraph each with an engineering example (5 × 2 = 10): two-way feedback, pooled expertise at a design review, commitment through joint decisions, coordination between site and design office, official record in minutes. Weaknesses (3 × 2 = 6): cost in salary hours, domination and groupthink, delayed decisions. Conclusion (2): meetings work when they have a clear objective, an agenda, a firm chair and action minutes.

Sources used in this whitepaper

American Psychological Association (2020) *Publication Manual of the American Psychological Association*. 7th edn. Washington, DC: APA.

Bovee, C.L. and Thill, J.V. (2021) *Business Communication Today*. 15th edn. Harlow: Pearson.

Guffey, M.E. and Loewy, D. (2022) *Essentials of Business Communication*. 11th edn. Boston: Cengage.

Locker, K.O. and Kaczmarek, S.K. (2014) *Business Communication: Building Critical Skills*. 6th edn. New York: McGraw-Hill.

National University of Science and Technology (2014; 2015) *TIE 1102 Engineering Communication Skills*, examination papers. Bulawayo: NUST.

Pauk, W. and Owens, R.J.Q. (2014) *How to Study in College*. 11th edn. Boston: Wadsworth (Cornell notes).

Pears, R. and Shields, G. (2022) *Cite Them Right*. 12th edn. London: Bloomsbury (Harvard).

TCW 1103 class presentations (2026): Macheke, T. *Meeting notice and meeting agenda*; plus topics on the memo, complaint letter, motivation letter, reports, chair and secretary, meetings and disciplinary hearings.